# No More Than a Stray Dog, After All

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Explicit

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Adora (She-Ra), Great Shinobi Owl

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by DrDrugtor


Summary

Adora has been training hard for this. Failure is not an option. As she draws her blade, she raises the katana next to her head with both hands, it's tip staring at her master. Her mind was empty, devoid of all distractions, focused solely on the enemy as he drew his nodachi. One sentence lingered in Adora's mind: "Hesitation is defeat."

This time, Adora won't go down. This time, she will win.

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The Sekiro-inspired oneshot no one(no, literally no one, not even me) asked for.
(Rated Explicit for safety)


Notes

See the end of the work for notes

An unending, rhythmical flurry of clangs. To the participants, each and every one a shout, reverberating within their ears, threatening to deafen. The flashes of steel as they meet and bounce off of each other, sparkling hard enough to ignite the wheat beneath them, should it not be raining. Their muscles shaking, going numb from withstanding and delivering all the blows. Their joints on fire, ready to snap at the slightest mistake of technique. The air, the night sky, offering it's soothing yet cold, biting fresh air that permeates their being. The rain, cooling down their weapons, the dissipating heat from the weapons emitting steam, ensuring their katanas don't melt.

It was dark, the only form of illumination the moon that shone brightly, behind clouds of darkness, just enough to highlight the participants. Their stage, a field of wheat, gently swaying in the wind, singing a lullaby, caressing the warriors as though they wish to alleviate the pain in their strained legs. Kiais, followed by even louder clangs, resonating the nearby wheat to their roots. Each and every breath a challenge, like a swing of a katana, knowing when to draw it, when to sheathe it.

The younger participant, a young woman by the name of Adora, grit her teeth. All she could taste was sweat and rain...and lately, copper, as she swallowed more of it from her mouth, wincing as she parried yet another blow at her head, her swollen left eye barely open. Numerous parts of her body were of a different colour.

Wherever her skin was exposed were also where her clothes were tattered, her normally pale skin marked in deep or shallow lines of red. There was no trickling of blood however, whatever droplets escaped her body were sent flying into whatever direction they could, painting the wheat, her, or her opponent, in red. The second kind of non-indigenous colour that adorned her body was a deep purple. One would think she wore it as make-up, judging by the amount present on her face. The rest were present on her shoulders, with one exceptionally large residing on her right thigh, on the outer side, the result of a devastating kick she barely

blocked instead, avoiding a dislodged knee...of course, based on how discoloured it became, or the pain she felt when the bone seemed to crack, Adora thought it might have just ripped her leg off at the knee.

Her opponent was, of course, free of injuries, though he too is suffering the effects of the prolonged combat. If there was a time when the two did not trade blows for maybe two seconds, it felt like seasons passed. As rare as those precious seconds are, they are perhaps the most important seconds. Recovery of your state of mind and body, controlling your breathing, watching for signs of attacks, feints, tricks and baits, there are many things to check of the list. All just to continue a dance that leaves just one of them standing, the other one embracing the wheat bellow.

Another sequence, this one initiated by Adora. She leaned forward, getting on her hand holding her katana. She leapt towards the old man, doing a sideways summersault that ended in her landing her right arm at her opponent. Her katana deflected, the tall man swiped from his right side, above his head, with both hands, intending to decapitate Adora as she was in the process of standing up. A deflection of relative ease, one followed by the old owl now dashing to his left so fast, so far, Adora could not keep up. The scars on her ribs taught her what he's trying to do though. Adora jumped, just barely avoiding the perilous swipe of her master. They passed each other as they both went different directions. Adora jumping to the right, her master rolling to the her left, along with his swing. The old man's roll was angled however, agile as a cat. As a result, he was facing Adora's direction as he stood up.

In a blink of an eye, he jumped, like an owl on the hunt, twisting his body in the air, cutting through the air like a bolt, shot from a crossbow. As he spun, so did his nodachi, the blade glinting as the moon drew attention to a strike that could cut Adora's stomach open, ending her through disembowelment.

The initial strike was parried, perfectly, as fiery sparks flew to the side, evaporating the incoming droplets of rain. After that followed

the signature move of the old man. While still in front of Adora, he spun around to his right side, delivering two alarmingly quick slashes with the nodachi in his right hand. The first, from bellow his waist, upwards, aimed at Adora's chest. The second, sparks still flying from the large weapon after the first parried slash, from his right, at shoulder level, straight to Adora's neck. Both were parried beautifully. Adora more or less had to though, considering how many times she suffered the consequences.

Unrelenting, Adora pressed the attack, actually managing to graze her master's triceps on his right arm. Dumbfounded, her master jumped back after easily parrying an ambitious attack aimed at his neck from Adora, barking a laugh.

"Very good!" The first words said in what feels like forever. He smiled, then frowned. He ran forwards, slashing once, vertically. Adora easily deflected it...but then, her master jumped into the air, raising his right leg, intending to kick her in the face. It was so fast, she couldn't raise her katana to parry in a way that would at least graze his foot. The vertical strike ensured her blade would be on her side, positioning it to allow a kick she could not possibly punish. So she decided to shoulder the kick, literally, wincing as her bruise probably worsened. As her master leapt into the air once more, gracious as ever despite his age, he ripped open a pouch at his belt, spreading some sort of liquid towards Adora. A moment too late she recognised it, dashing backwards. The poison cut through the air, the rain, it's acid so powerful the droplets merely needed to be in it's vicinity to sizzle into steam.

She growled, a few drops of acidic poison burning through her already tattered training clothes and gear. She went to observe her master, but saw nothing in front of her. She looked up just in time to see him jump and spin forwards, blade ready to cut her in half, vertically, starting with her head. Her feet felt like they were turned into stone. She raised her arms, just in time to avoid certain death, but the attack sent her reeling backwards, groaning as she felt the pressure almost crack her spine, her ribs tense, burning as all the oxygen was knocked out of her body. Her teeth

smashed against each other, blood surging in her mouth once more.

Stepping back, she raised her arms, katana raised right next to her head. Her vision was blurry, but she will not show weakness. Slow and steady, she drew shallow breaths, commanding her lungs to bear the pain and endure. Another painstaking moment of silence. The wind picked up, as if trying to smooth things over, to end the conflict.

It did not.

And so came another flurry of attacks, this time initiated mostly by the old owl. Adora was running on fumes, and the man knew it. Adora was tenacious though, and until she can breathe, she will not falter. She stumbled backwards, to the side, as she now struggled to keep up with the devastating overhead strikes. Her legs shook, staggering, upon keeping the swiping attacks from cutting her in half. Her ankles popped as she landed roughly from the jumps, her master's perilous attacks unblockable in any capacity. Shurikens flew her way, so fast all she could do in her state was ensure they do not embed themselves into her body once again, hissing as the shurikens bounced off of her katana, grazing her flesh, so sharp, so precise they cut raindrops in half as they scattered onto the field.

An overhead strike, parried. With both their weapons on the side, the old owl turned to his side, bashing Adora on the shoulder with his own. After that came another one of the old man's sneakiest tactics. Following the shoulder-bash, he turned right, striking from the left. Nothing out of the ordinary, as it did not carry too much weight behind it. However, as he swiped, his arm readying for a slow, calculated follow-up attack, Adora noticed the gunpowder that flew towards her, almost engulfing her. She had no time to react. As the swing came, the gunpowder ignited. Adora deflected the nodachi, but combined with her weary state, and the shockwave of the gunpowder, she was sent reeling back, stabbing her katana in the ground for support, her clothes now scorched.

To say she was tired would be an underestimation. She was beyond exhausted, her body felt like it was barely kept together by her still intact bones, sinews and muscles ready to snap at any moment. Visibly shaking, she frowned, readying her katana from the ground, next to her head once more. No matter how little she could see with one good eye remaining, no matter how blistered and scorched her face became, she cannot surrender. It is not an option, if she is to do what must be done.

One last barrage. This one, devoid of mercy. Poison, shurikens, gunpowder, feints, perilous swipes. By now, not a single attack was deflected. Adora merely held up her arms, clutching the katana, withstanding the incoming strikes through pure physical prowess, her musculature not just for show. A curtain of gunpowder, as the old man jumped back. Right before the gunpowder exploded, sending fire and steam into the air, she saw it. Her master readied himself, sending his sword behind him, the tip of the nodachi facing her. He leaned down, crouching, his left arm outstretched towards Adora, sizing her up.

The wind's howling picked up in protest, as if not wanting to further witness this delayed execution.

The gunpowder exploded, her master now out of sight, behind the curtain of fire and steam. She knew better. On que, the old man re-appeared, lunging towards Adora, ready to gore her with the nodachi, it's size equal to Adora, almost. The smoke trailed in his wake, curling after him.

She knew what she had to do. She has been taught the technique. She practised it, every day, every night, for weeks. She didn't know if she had it in herself to pull it off, though. She relies on her left leg for it, but her right leg is almost completely useless, the bruise on it made sure of that. So she committed a grand mistake. She hesitated. In the last moment, she raised her blade, meeting her master's nodachi. A deflection, if one can call it that. The nodachi grazed her right shoulder, cutting it open just bellow the local bruise. Following that, using his momentum, the old man jumped into the air, sending Adora backwards. With all

her remaining strength, she seemed to trick her brain into sending her into another adrenaline rush, hellbent on quickly turning the tide of the battle. As he came crashing down on Adora, he delivered a swift swipe, followed by a spin that generated powerful winds, ended by yet another spin as he landed, graciously as ever, dominant arm and nodachi outstretched towards the night sky, as the burst of wind left his aura, sending Adora backwards, her ponytail swaying back and forth like a banner.

He followed it up immediately, having the same thought as Adora, to end this duel. He raised his left arm above his head and threw a shuriken in Adora's direction, with as much force as he could muster. Since it's relative slowness, she could deflect the tiny object, even with one eye.

However, as he threw the shuriken, the old man took one step with his left leg, dashing forwards. Readying the nodachi to be on his left, in contact with the ground, he gripped it with both his hands, effortlessly cutting down some stray wheat along the way. Adora's eyes widened. As the attack landed, less than half a meter away from her, the old man let out a kiai, cutting diagonally, aiming at Adora's midsection. She managed to deflect, but the sheer power behind the attack sent her flying into the air anyway, half-standing as she landed on her left knee, almost dropping her katana.

The following moment lasted for about three seconds, yet it felt like an hour. An agonizing hour Adora will not soon forget.

Seeing her on the ground, the old man spun, this time to his left, readying his left foot to stomp on Adora and seal her fate with a swift strike. It never arrived though, as she rolled beneath his leg, positioning herself behind her master. With all the strength she could muster, she raised her katana, planting the palm of her left hand onto the weapon's pommel, going for a stab. Before she knew it, the wind was knocked out of her, both her arms facing downwards, her katana firmly shoved into the ground. On top of it, her master's foot. She didn't dare look up. She knew her

mistake. Impatience, pride, arrogance. She awaited her punishment.

As the conclusion of the duel drew near, the moon shied away from having to witness the final strokes of this painting, hiding behind the dark clouds that continued to pour rain, ever so feverish.

Her master jumped above her, sending Adora onto her knees, both arms on the ground. The old master twisted his lower body around, in a circular motion, his head and upper body moving only to help his smooth landing. As he jumped, he twisted the nodachi in his hand to grip it backwards, cutting open Adora's back mid-jump, slicing up her flesh, severing her spine. Then, as soft as a whisper, he landed. The cut drew out whatever energy her body had as she straightened out, kneeling, arms bent, instincts making her try to grab onto anything to help deal with the pain.

For the finale, the master planted the palm of his left hand onto the pommel of his nodachi. Mouth agape, teeth bared in the form of a silent scream, she made no sound as the nodachi pierced her from behind.

Slowly, he withdrew the blade, now coated in his apprentice's blood. She slumped onto the cold, wet field of wheat. It was hard to make out what made the splatter louder, the rain seeped into the ground, or her blood that pooled under her before she even made contact with the ground.

"You've fought well today." he cleaned his blade on the crook of his elbow, the fabric of his attire stained in crimson at the bend of his sleeve.

"Return to the castle when you are ready, we will resume your training tomorrow." He sheathed his weapon into the scabbard on his back. Adora merely gargled on her own blood in response, closing her eyes.

End Notes

I apologize on behalf of all my ancestors for this mess. I will be 100% honest, I have no idea what I wrote or why I wrote it. Yesterday this scene just climbed it's way into my brain and I couldn't let it go. For context, I was watching some Sekiro clips, and also reading Jakes_Alright's fiction, Would You Still Read Me Baby (If I weren't required?). (I recommend you give it a read, in my opinion it might as well be reported due to how illegally good it is)

For some bizarre reason I thought, what if I were to make a oneshot that combines She-ra, Harry Potter and sprinkle in some Sekiro elements? Originally, my take was going to be that in this Harry Potter setting AU(not Jakes_Alright's, of course), all stays Harry Potter-esque, including the main plot of the og Harry Potter(and somehow squeeze in the Catradora angst+love), with the addition that there are not just pure wizards, but wizards reminiscent of D&D style eldritch knights(melee fighters with a bit of magic on the side), because I think that would be cool.

So, uhm, yeah, if you made it this far, thanks very much, if not, oh well, no harm no foul, I more or less just scrambled down what ideas I had, apologies if it's a bit incoherent. If you liked it, do let me know, who knows, maybe one day I will actually turn this into a coherent fiction, wouldn't that be something?

Stay safe, have a good day/night :D

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